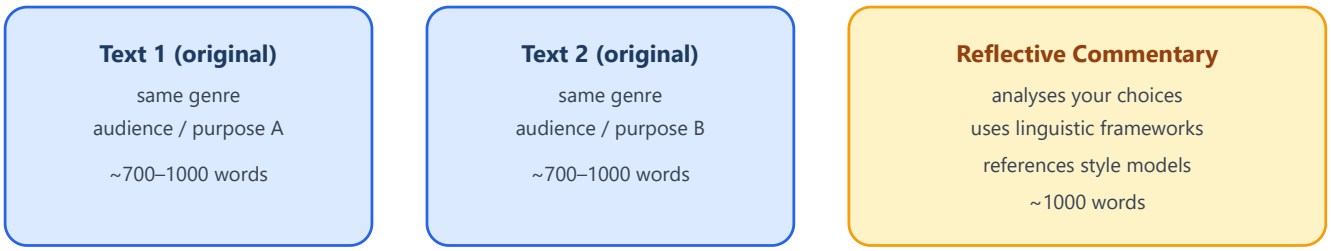
RAG Learning

4.1 Crafting Language (NEA)

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Non-Exam Assessment

The Edexcel NEA is called **Crafting Language** and is worth 20% of the A-Level. You produce **two original texts in the SAME genre** (e.g. two feature articles, two short stories, two speeches) for **different audiences or purposes**, plus a **reflective commentary** that analyses your linguistic choices and your research process. You must include a **bibliography** of style models and any academic sources consulted.

Structure of the Edexcel NEA (Crafting Language)



4.1.1 Choosing a Genre

The Edexcel spec allows a wide range of genres. Your two texts must be in the **SAME** genre. Examples:

Genre	Possible audience / purpose pairing
Feature journalism	Broadsheet readership vs specialist interest magazine
Short story	Adult literary audience vs young-adult (YA) fiction
Travel writing	Luxury travel magazine vs backpacker blog

Speeches	Campaign speech to voters vs acceptance speech to industry peers
Investigative journalism	Longform print piece vs online-first reporting
Blogs / digital essays	Personal blog for friends vs public-facing expert blog

Choose a genre you find genuinely interesting and where you can ACCESS good style models.

4.1.2 Style Models

A **style model** is a published text you study as a reference for your own writing. You should:

- Choose well-crafted, published texts in your target genre.
- Annotate them — identify specific features you want to learn from.
- Reference them explicitly in the commentary — what you adopted, adapted, or deliberately rejected.
- Submit style-model references in your bibliography.

The style model is NOT to be copied. Plagiarism — direct copying of wording — is disqualifying. The NEA rewards *informed adaptation*: you use the style model to learn craft, then apply that learning to your own content.

4.1.3 Designing Two Contrasting Texts

The two texts must differ in audience or purpose — this is the CORE of the assessment. Example pairings:

- **Same genre, different audience:** a travel article for a luxury magazine vs the same trip written for a budget-travel blog.
- **Same genre, different purpose:** a feature article celebrating a local sports team vs one campaigning for funding for the same team.
- **Same genre, different mode:** a short story as a published literary piece vs a short story as a social-media serial (different length constraints, different visual presentation).

Your COMMENTARY then argues WHY each text has the linguistic features it does — informed by the contrast.

4.1.4 Research & the Bibliography

Edexcel explicitly expects research. Your NEA should be informed by:

- **Genre research** — reading multiple published examples to internalise conventions.
- **Audience research** — identifying register, lexical and graphological features your target readers expect.
- **Theoretical reading** — applying concepts from Paper 1, 2 or 3: synthetic personalisation (Fairclough), face (Brown & Levinson), narrative structure, Halliday\'s metafunctions.
- **Corpus evidence** — where useful, checking frequencies in the British National Corpus or similar to verify register.

The bibliography should follow a consistent style (Harvard is common) and include all style models and academic / reference sources.

4.1.5 Craft Principles Across Genres

Whatever your genre, strong writing displays:

- **Audience awareness** — every lexical, grammatical, graphological and pragmatic choice responds to your reader.
- **Purpose clarity** — every paragraph moves the purpose forward.
- **Register consistency** — or deliberate, signalled shifts.
- **Syntactic variety** — mix of sentence lengths and structures for rhythm.
- **Concrete detail** — named, sensory, specific.
- **Controlled structure** — clear opening, purposeful middle, satisfying end.

4.1.6 Techniques by Genre

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Persuasive writing

- Triadic / rule-of-three structures for rhythm.
- Parallelism — repeated grammatical shapes.
- Inclusive "we" and direct address.
- Modal verbs of obligation — "must", "should".
- Rhetorical questions engaging reader reasoning.
- Anecdote opening + imperative call to action in closing.

Storytelling / short fiction

- Strong narrative voice — consistent idiolect.
- Show, don\'t tell — concrete sensory detail.
- Scene and summary — scene-building at key moments, summary for bridges.
- Dialogue revealing character, not just plot.
- Pacing through sentence length and paragraphing.
- In medias res opening; dramatic irony where relevant.

Journalism

- Strong lead paragraph answering who/what/when/where.
- Inverted-pyramid structure in hard news.
- Integration of quotation with attribution.
- Clear headlines; subheads for navigation.
- First-person voice for opinion / column; third-person for report.

Travel writing / blogs

- Anecdotal first-person opening.
- Concrete sensory lexis — place-specific detail.
- Balance of personal voice and factual information.
- Reflective closing drawing the piece together.

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4.1.7 The Commentary

The commentary is analytical, not creative. It uses linguistic frameworks to reflect on your choices.

What the commentary must do

- Explain your **intended audience and purpose** for each text.
- Discuss your **style models** — what you adopted, adapted, or deliberately did differently.
- Analyse your **linguistic choices** at multiple levels using precise terminology.
- Quote from your own texts as evidence.
- Reflect honestly on what worked and what did not — including alternatives considered.
- Address BOTH texts, noting specifically what changes for the different audience/purpose.

Commentary paragraph structure

1. **Feature identified** — "My opening uses a fronted prepositional phrase…"
2. **Quotation from your piece** — "'Beyond the ridge, she waited.'"
3. **Framework terminology** — "The fronting delays the subject, foregrounding setting."
4. **Effect on reader** — "This builds suspense in the first sentence."
5. **Link to style model** — "I adapted this from Ishiguro\'s use of spatial disorientation in *The Remains of the Day*."
6. **Contrast across texts** — "For my second text (YA audience) I chose a shorter declarative opening, reflecting the expectation of pacier YA narrative."

Worked Example: A strong commentary sentence (for paired persuasive speeches on climate action): "*The triadic imperative close — \'Act. Demand. Change.\' — draws on Obama\'s 2008 victory speech (my first style model), which I annotated for its rhythmic three-part closers. For the industry-peer speech (Text 2), I softened the triad using modals: \'We could act. We should demand. We will change.\' — the modal progression fits a professional audience less amenable to blunt directives.*" Quotation + framework + effect + style model + cross-text contrast — all in two sentences.

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4.1.8 What the Commentary Should NOT Do

- **Retell the plot** — the marker has read your texts.
- **Merely describe** — "I used an adjective" without naming the effect is AO1 at its weakest.
- **Ignore the style models** — they are the basis of informed craft.
- **Avoid frameworks** — you must use the six linguistic levels and theory from Papers 1–3.
- **Only praise yourself** — honest critical reflection scores higher.
- **Treat the two texts separately** — the assessment is about CONTROLLED VARIATION across them.

4.1.9 Tips for Drafting

1. Choose your genre + two style models *before* drafting.
2. Annotate style models carefully — 6–10 features each.
3. Plan each text\'s audience and purpose explicitly in writing.
4. Draft Text 1. Revise.
5. Draft Text 2, deliberately varying features for the new audience/purpose.
6. Revise Text 2.
7. Draft commentary paragraph by paragraph, each addressing a specific feature in one or both texts.
8. Proof-read all three submissions as distinct pieces of writing.
9. Compile bibliography in consistent style.

4.1.10 Plagiarism and Originality

Your original texts must be your own work. You can learn from style models but you cannot lift their phrasing. Informed adaptation (using the same rhetorical technique with your own content) is expected and rewarded. Direct copying is plagiarism and disqualifying.

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Your teacher can advise on scope, genre and methodology. They cannot write or rewrite your work. Keep drafts to show progression; they support authentication.

4.1.11 Example Project Timeline

Week	Task
1	Choose genre. Read widely.
2	Select two style models. Annotate.
3	Plan both texts. Define each audience/purpose explicitly.
4–5	Draft Text 1. Revise.
6–7	Draft Text 2. Revise.
8	Draft commentary.
9	Revise commentary in light of final versions.
10	Proof-read all three; compile bibliography; submit.

4.1.12 Assessment Objectives Assessed by the NEA

- **AO1** — Apply appropriate methods of language analysis, using associated terminology and coherent written expression (commentary).
- **AO2** — Demonstrate critical understanding of concepts and issues relevant to language use (commentary).
- **AO3** — Analyse and evaluate how contextual factors and language features are associated with the construction of meaning (commentary).
- **AO5** — Demonstrate expertise and creativity in the use of English in different ways, for different purposes, genres and audiences (original texts).

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NEA Tip: The commentary should feel as crafted as the original pieces. Treat it as a distinct act of writing in its own right, using academic register, precise terminology, integrated quotation and honest reflection. Top-band commentaries consistently address BOTH texts in the same paragraph, showing how each choice differs for each audience.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define and apply: **genre conventions, style model, annotation, audience, purpose, register, idiolect, narrative voice, triadic structure, parallelism, anaphora, modality, inclusive "we", anecdote, in medias res, dramatic irony, sensory imagery, concrete vs abstract lexis, register shift, synthetic personalisation, commentary, bibliography.** Know the **AO descriptors** and how they apply to each component.

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